

Problem-Solving Framework for Claude Code

Course reference

COURSE	AI Workshop 2.0, Desktop Edition
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YOU NEED	A Mac or PC and a paid Claude plan

Course reference

The skill you're developing: Conversational Problem-Solving with AI

WHY -- Why This Matters

Most people think they need to learn "prompt engineering" to use AI. They don't. The question you'd ask a friend is already the right prompt.

The problem isn't *how* to ask -- it's what to do when the first answer doesn't work. This framework gives you a repeatable system for unsticking yourself, without needing anyone else's help.

Before: You get stuck, close the terminal, wait for someone to help. **After:** You follow a 3-level system that solves 90% of problems yourself.

WHAT -- What You'll Learn

A 3-level problem-solving system, from simple to advanced:

```
%%{init: {'theme': 'dark', 'themeVariables': {'nodeTextColor': '#e8e8e8',
'primaryTextColor': '#e8e8e8', 'secondaryTextColor': '#cccccc', 'tertiaryTextColor':
'cccccc', 'clusterBkg': 'transparent', 'clusterBorder': '#8b949e'}}}%
flowchart LR
    A["Level 1<br/>Just Ask"] --> B["Level 2<br/>Add Context"]
    B --> C["Level 3<br/>Give Claude<br/>Your File"]

    style A fill:none,stroke:#3fb950,stroke-width:2px,color:#c9d1d9
    style B fill:none,stroke:#d29922,stroke-width:2px,color:#c9d1d9
    style C fill:none,stroke:#f85149,stroke-width:2px,color:#c9d1d9
```

Level 1: Just Ask

Your question IS the prompt. Write it exactly as you'd say it out loud.

```
%%{init: {'theme': 'dark', 'themeVariables': {'nodeTextColor': '#e8e8e8',
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'cccccc', 'clusterBkg': 'transparent', 'clusterBorder': '#8b949e'}}}%
flowchart LR
    A["Write your<br/>question"] --> B["Ask Claude<br/>that exact<br/>question"]
    B --> C["Did it<br/>work?"]
    C -->|Yes| D[Done]
    C -->|No| E["Ask a<br/>follow-up"]
    E --> F{Now?}
    F -->|Yes| D
    F -->|No| G["Go to<br/>Level 2"]

    style A fill:none,stroke:#8b949e,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style B fill:none,stroke:#8b949e,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style C fill:none,stroke:#d29922,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style D fill:none,stroke:#3fb950,stroke-width:2px,color:#c9d1d9
    style E fill:none,stroke:#8b949e,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style F fill:none,stroke:#d29922,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style G fill:none,stroke:#f85149,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
```

Follow-up phrases that work:

- "That didn't work because..."
- "I tried that but..."
- "Can you explain that differently?"

- "I got this error: [paste the error]"

Level 2: Add Context Variables

When Level 1 isn't enough, give Claude more to work with. Think of it as three variables:

YOUR QUESTION + WHAT + WHERE + HOW

"I'm trying to [WHAT] and I'm at [WHERE].
Can you help me with [HOW]?"

VARIABLE	ASK YOURSELF	EXAMPLES
WHAT	What am I trying to achieve?	"Set up CLAUDE.md", "Create a command", "Install an MCP"
WHERE	Where am I in the process?	"Module 3", "Just starting", "Stuck at the install step"
HOW	How do I want the answer?	"Step by step", "Quick answer", "Explain like I'm new"

Example prompt:

"I'm trying to CREATE a slash command and I'm at Module 3. Can you give me a step-by-step guide?"

Two more variables if you're debugging:

VARIABLE	ASK YOURSELF	EXAMPLES
WHY	Why isn't it working?	"Error says...", "Nothing happens when..."
CONTEXT	What have I tried?	"I followed the steps but...", "Claude said X but..."

Level 3: Give Claude Your Self-Drive File

For maximum help, paste the self-drive file from whatever module you're working on. Claude then has the EXACT context and can help you properly.

IF YOU'RE WORKING ON...	GIVE CLAUDE THIS FILE
Installing Claude Code	Module-000.../INSTALL-SELF-DRIVE.md
Setting up Copilot	Module-00.../COPILOT-SELF-DRIVE.md
Setting up CLAUDE.md	Module-1.../CLAUDE-MD-SELF-DRIVE.md
Creating your session log	Module-2.../MASTER-LOG-SELF-DRIVE.md
Commands and skills	Module-3.../SLASH-COMMANDS-SELF-DRIVE.md
Installing MCPs	Module-4.../MCP-SELF-DRIVE.md
Building agents	Module-5.../AGENTS-SELF-DRIVE.md

How:

1. Open the self-drive file for your current module
2. Copy its contents
3. Paste it to Claude with your question:

"Here's the self-drive file I'm following:

[paste the file]

My question is: [your question]"

Still Stuck? Use the Question Helper

If you can't even articulate what you're asking, open `QUESTION-HELPER.pdf`, then ask Claude the question it helps you shape. Claude will walk you through a 5-step process to figure out what your question actually is.

HOW -- Using This Framework

```
%%{init: {'theme': 'dark', 'themeVariables': {'nodeTextColor': '#e8e8e8',
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'cccccc', 'clusterBkg': 'transparent', 'clusterBorder': '#8b949e'}}}%
flowchart LR
    A["You have<br/>a question"] --> B["Level 1:<br/>Just ask it"]
    B --> C{Solved?}
    C -->|Yes| D[Done]
    C -->|No| E["Level 2:<br/>Add variables"]
    E --> F{Solved?}
    F -->|Yes| D
    F -->|No| G["Level 3:<br/>Paste your<br/>self-drive file"]
    G --> H{Solved?}
    H -->|Yes| D
    H -->|No| I["Use<br/>Question<br/>Helper"]

    style A fill:none,stroke:#8b949e,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style B fill:none,stroke:#3fb950,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
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    style G fill:none,stroke:#f85149,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style H fill:none,stroke:#d29922,stroke-width:1px,color:#c9d1d9
    style I fill:none,stroke:#f85149,stroke-width:2px,color:#c9d1d9
```

Quick Reference Checklist

- [] Did I write my question down in plain English?
- [] Did I ask Claude that exact question? (Level 1)
- [] Did I try a follow-up when the first answer didn't work?
- [] Did I add WHAT / WHERE / HOW variables? (Level 2)
- [] Did I paste my self-drive file for context? (Level 3)
- [] Did I use the Question Helper as a last resort?

WHAT IF -- What This Unlocks

This framework isn't just for this course. It's the same process you'll use for every AI interaction going forward:

- **At work** -- "Claude, here's my spreadsheet. The totals in column F don't match. Can you find the formula error?"
- **At home** -- "Claude, I want to organise my photos by date. What's the easiest way on Mac?"
- **In this course** -- every module gets easier because you know how to unstick yourself

The pattern never changes: **ask, refine, give context**. The more you practise it here, the more natural it becomes everywhere else.

Part of AI Workshop 2.0 -- SSL 26 Edition